

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Insurance English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For underwriters, claims adjusters, brokers, risk managers, actuarial analysts, policy-service teams, compliance staff, and insurance operations leaders.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Underwriting and Risk Selection

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Policy Language and Coverage Interpretation

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

03 Claims Intake and Reserving

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Coverage Disputes and Denials

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Broker and Client Renewal Meetings

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

06 Fraud Indicators and SIU Referral

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

07 Actuarial Assumptions and Pricing

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

08 Compliance, Market Conduct, and Complaints

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Underwriting and Risk Selection

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

An underwriting submission describes a business activity broadly but omits its operating locations and loss history.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: underwriting, risk appetite, exposure, loss history.

Model response

Could you confirm the activities, locations, and requested loss-history information? Those details will help the underwriting team assess the submission without relying on assumptions about the business.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Which operations and locations are included? - Fictional underwriting intake: a submission says business services but omits operating locations and loss history. No coverage or acceptance decision is made.
2. Storage or manufacturing? - Separate fictional submission: a facility is described as a warehouse, but an attachment mentions assembly work; the extent of that activity is unspecified.

3. A blank loss field is not a clean history - Separate fictional renewal submission: the loss-history field is blank; the broker has not established whether records are unavailable or no losses were reported.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Is the third site operating or planned?

A fictional submission lists three operating sites, but a separate note calls one site planned for next year. Its current operating status is unverified. Clarify the location schedule before underwriting review.

Role A: Underwriting analyst: ask whether the third site is current or proposed.

Role B: Broker coordinator: agree to obtain the client's verified status without removing the site on assumption.

Possible opening: Could you clarify whether the third location is operating now or is only planned?

Success checks

- Distinguish current operations from plans.
- Preserve the unresolved site information.
- Avoid promising an underwriting outcome.

Add a complication: The broker asks whether excluding it would guarantee acceptance.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Policy Language and Coverage Interpretation

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A client sees a policy summary and assumes it includes every term of coverage. The full policy has endorsements and exclusions.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: policy, endorsement, exclusion, coverage.

Model response

The summary is an overview. The actual policy wording, including endorsements and exclusions, needs to be reviewed for the coverage question. Let's identify the relevant documents and ask the appropriate specialist to clarify them.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. A summary does not contain every policy term - Fictional policy-document discussion: a summary is available alongside a full policy with endorsements and exclusions; no specific loss is interpreted.

2. A certificate is not the whole contract - Separate fictional document-coordination case: a client provides a certificate as proof of detailed coverage terms, but the applicable policy wording has not been reviewed.

3. A requested endorsement has not been issued - Separate fictional policy-service case: a broker requested a location endorsement, but no issued endorsement or confirmed effective date is available.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two policy years in one folder

A fictional client folder contains a current-year summary and a prior-year endorsement. No current-year equivalent has been confirmed. Explain why the documents cannot simply be combined into one coverage description.

Role A: Policy documentation specialist: distinguish the periods and request the applicable current documents.

Role B: Client insurance manager: paraphrase the issue and ask what remains unknown.

Possible opening: These documents concern different policy years, so we need the applicable current set before describing coverage.

Success checks

- Identify the policy-period mismatch.
- Avoid assuming continuity of terms.
- Agree a document request and qualified review.

Add a complication: The client assumes last year's endorsement automatically applies unchanged.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Claims Intake and Reserving

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A claim report lacks the event date and supporting documents. The intake team needs a clear follow-up request.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: claim, reserve, proof of loss, adjuster.

Model response

Could you provide the event date and the requested supporting records through the secure channel? If an item is unavailable, please tell us so the claim team can explain the next step.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Request the event date and supporting documents - Fictional claims intake: an initial report lacks an event date and supporting documents; no coverage or payment outcome is known.
2. A document list needs a realistic response point - Separate fictional claim-coordination case: an adjuster requests an invoice and photographs; the broker has the photographs but must retrieve the invoice.

3. Clarify whose estimate is attached - Separate fictional intake case: a repair estimate is attached without identifying its preparer or assessment date; no amount is approved.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two dates need their own labels

A fictional claim form lists March 4 and March 9 without labels. The event date and reporting date are both required, but their mapping is unknown. Ask the broker to obtain a verified clarification.

Role A: Claims intake coordinator: request the meaning of each date and explain why guessing is inappropriate.

Role B: Broker claims representative: agree to ask the client and return a factual answer.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which date describes the event and which describes reporting, rather than choosing from their order?

Success checks

- Keep both date meanings unconfirmed.
- Request verification from the appropriate source.
- Avoid inferring coverage or a deadline from the unlabeled dates.

Add a complication: The broker wants to select the earlier date automatically.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Coverage Disputes and Denials

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A client asks whether a reported loss is definitely covered. The claim review is still underway.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: denial, reservation of rights, appeal, coverage position.

Model response

The coverage review is still underway, so I cannot confirm the outcome. I can explain what information has been received, what remains outstanding, and how the team will communicate its decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. Review underway is not confirmed coverage - Fictional claims discussion: a reported loss remains under review; no coverage position has been finalized.
2. A reservation letter is not necessarily a final denial - Separate fictional case: a file contains a reservation-of-rights letter, but the team's summary calls the claim denied; the full case position needs

authorized review.

3. A similar paid claim does not settle this loss - Separate fictional broker meeting: a client cites a previous paid claim, but the present loss's facts and applicable wording are still being assessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A document request is called a denial

A fictional claimant receives a request for additional evidence and tells the broker the claim has been denied. The case record says review pending, with no final position supplied. Explain the current status and request clarification of the outstanding evidence.

Role A: Broker claims coordinator: distinguish the information request from a finalized decision.

Role B: Claims liaison: confirm the recorded pending status and offer an authorized status check.

Possible opening: The record shows a request for more evidence, not a confirmed denial in the information we have.

Success checks

- Separate an evidence request from a final coverage decision.
- Preserve the pending outcome.
- Avoid guaranteeing approval or inventing appeal advice.

Add a complication: The broker asks you to promise approval as soon as the evidence arrives.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Broker and Client Renewal Meetings

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A renewal quote has a lower premium but a higher deductible. The client asks whether it is the same protection for less money.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: renewal, premium, deductible, reinsurance.

Model response

The premium is lower, but the deductible has changed. We should compare the coverage terms and other differences as well before describing the options as equivalent.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. B - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Lower premium, higher deductible - Fictional renewal comparison: A has a premium of 900 units and deductible of 200; B has a premium of 800 and deductible of 500. Other terms remain unreviewed.
2. A shorter quote period distorts the saving - Separate fictional renewal case: one quotation covers twelve months and another nine months; the scope and other terms have not been matched.

3. An additional service is not automatically broader coverage - Separate fictional renewal comparison: quote A includes a risk-review visit; quote B does not. Policy wording and the visit's scope remain unreviewed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two quotes use different insured values

Two fictional renewal quotations show different premiums, but one uses an insured value of 100,000 units and the other 80,000. Deductibles and detailed terms remain unreviewed. Discuss the mismatched basis and request a comparable quotation.

Role A: Broker renewal analyst: explain why the lower premium isn't yet an equivalent-price comparison.

Role B: Client finance manager: ask for matching assumptions and identify who will review the terms.

Possible opening: These quotes use different insured values, so the premium difference isn't a like-for-like saving yet.

Success checks

- Identify the differing insured values.
- Avoid recommending unsupported or inaccurate values.
- Request matched assumptions and qualified review.

Add a complication: The manager wants to use the lower value solely to obtain the cheaper quote.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Fraud Indicators and SIU Referral

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An unusual claim pattern prompts concern. A note calls the customer fraudulent before an investigation has established the facts.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: fraud indicator, SIU, material misrepresentation, investigation.

Model response

The pattern is an indicator for review, not proof of fraud. I'll describe the observed facts neutrally and route the concern through the appropriate investigation process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. An unusual pattern is not established fraud - Fictional internal referral: a claim pattern is unusual, but investigation has not established fraud; sensitive details remain in the approved internal channel.
2. Two matching amounts need context - Separate fictional internal review: two claims contain identical estimate amounts; preparers and underlying circumstances have not been compared.

3. A corrected answer does not establish intent - Separate fictional submission review: a customer corrects an earlier answer about an event; the reason for the difference has not been established.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A shared address prompts an unsupported accusation

Two fictional claims list the same business mailing address. The relationship between the claimants is unverified. An internal draft calls this coordinated fraud. Discuss a neutral referral without seeking sensitive details outside authorized channels.

Role A: Claims analyst: describe the shared address and unknown relationship.

Role B: Investigation liaison: challenge the conclusion and request an evidence-based internal summary.

Possible opening: The records share a mailing address, but that alone doesn't establish coordinated fraud.

Success checks

- Separate the shared address from an unproven allegation.
- Keep evidence and referral within authorized channels.
- Identify the relationship as unknown rather than inventing it.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests contacting unrelated people publicly to investigate the address.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Actuarial Assumptions and Pricing

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

An actuarial update shows claim costs rising because both the number of claims and average cost per claim increased.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: loss development, frequency, severity, reserve adequacy.

Model response

Both frequency and severity contributed to the increase. I'll show the number of claims separately from their average cost so the audience can understand the two drivers.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. More claims and costlier claims - Fictional actuarial explanation: comparable exposure periods show both increased claim frequency and increased average claim severity; no pricing decision is supplied.
2. Paid so far is not the final claim cost - Separate fictional actuarial briefing: a recent claim cohort has paid amounts recorded, but some claims remain open and development assumptions need review.

3. Claim counts need an exposure denominator - Separate fictional portfolio comparison: A records 20 claims across 1,000 policy-years; B records 30 across 3,000 policy-years, with comparable definitions assumed for this exercise.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An average is changed by one large claim

A fictional portfolio's average claim cost increased, and one unusually large claim is present. The analyst has not assessed how much it explains or whether frequency changed. Explain the difference between severity and a portfolio-wide claim trend.

Role A: Actuarial analyst: explain the average and the unassessed influence of the large claim.

Role B: Portfolio manager: ask which comparison would clarify the driver without discarding valid data.

Possible opening: Average severity rose, but we haven't measured how much the large claim explains or whether frequency changed.

Success checks

- Distinguish average severity from frequency.
- Preserve the claim in the evidence.
- Request transparent analysis rather than claim an established cause.

Add a complication: The manager suggests deleting the large claim solely to make the trend look better.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Compliance, Market Conduct, and Complaints

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A policyholder's complaint received a generic reply that did not address a specific fee question.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: market conduct, complaint, timely communication, corrective action.

Model response

Our earlier reply did not answer your fee question. I'm sorry. I'll record that point for review and explain the next step and expected update under our complaints process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. C - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. B - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. The generic reply missed the fee question - Fictional complaint review: a policyholder asked about a fee and received a generic response; the fee's case-specific basis has not been checked.

2. A complaint was acknowledged, not resolved - Separate fictional case: an automated message calls a complaint resolved when the record shows acknowledgment only; substantive review remains open.

3. A promised callback was not an agreed decision date - Separate fictional complaints case: an agent promised a decision during Friday's callback, although only a status update had been arranged with the review team.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The reply names the wrong complaint

A fictional policyholder complained about a delayed document, but the reply discusses a payment dispute. Neither issue has been reviewed in this case. Correct the mismatch and agree a check of the actual document request.

Role A: Complaints supervisor: acknowledge that the response addressed the wrong subject.

Role B: Broker service coordinator: explain the policyholder's actual concern and ask who will check the document status.

Possible opening: Our reply addressed a payment dispute, but your client's complaint concerns a delayed document.

Success checks

- Correct the subject without blaming the policyholder.
- Keep document delivery timing unconfirmed.
- Assign the document-status follow-up.

Add a complication: The coordinator asks for a guaranteed delivery date before the document team responds.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Insurance English

Professional audience: underwriters, claims adjusters, brokers, risk managers, actuarial analysts, policy-service teams, compliance staff, and insurance operations leaders

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Underwriting and Risk Selection

Original fictional case: An underwriting submission describes a business activity broadly but omits its operating locations and loss history.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: underwriting: Evaluation of risk and terms used to decide whether and on what conditions to issue insurance, extend credit, or accept an investment exposure. / risk appetite: The amount and types of risk an organization is prepared to pursue or retain. / exposure: The extent to which people, assets, or operations are subject to a hazard or potential loss. / loss history: A record of prior claims or losses for an insured risk.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you confirm the activities, locations, and requested loss-history information? Those details will help the underwriting team assess the submission without relying on assumptions about the business.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Insurance English

Professional audience: underwriters, claims adjusters, brokers, risk managers, actuarial analysts, policy-service teams, compliance staff, and insurance operations leaders

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Underwriting and Risk Selection

Original fictional case: An underwriting submission describes a business activity broadly but omits its operating locations and loss history.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: underwriting: Evaluation of risk and terms used to decide whether and on what conditions to issue insurance, extend credit, or accept an investment exposure. / risk appetite: The amount and types of risk an organization is prepared to pursue or retain. / exposure: The extent to which people, assets, or operations are subject to a hazard or potential loss. / loss history: A record of prior claims or losses for an insured risk.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you confirm the activities, locations, and requested loss-history information? Those details will help the underwriting team assess the submission without relying on assumptions about the business.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level